

Chapter 12:

Choosing the Right Type of Report

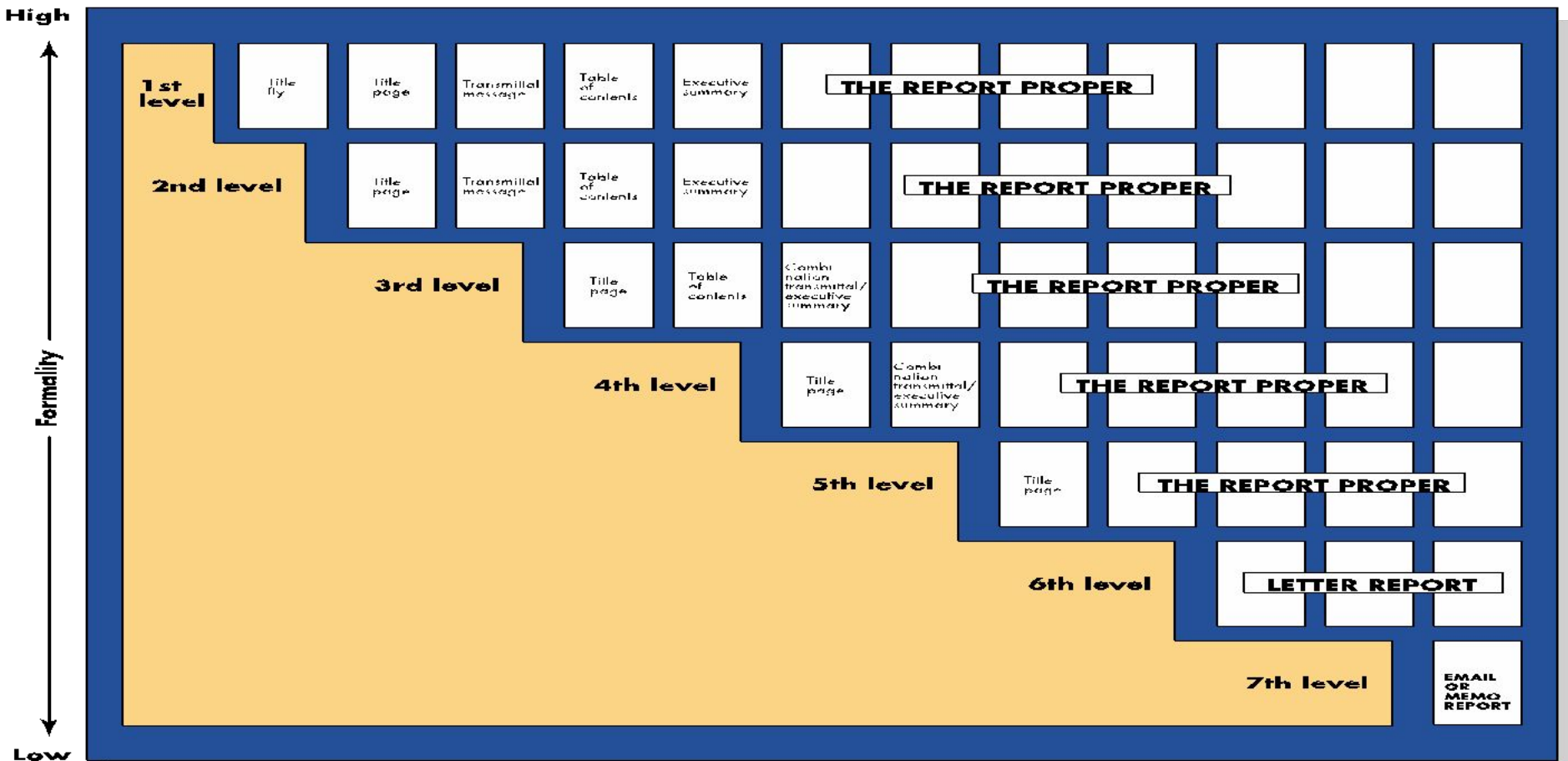
Overview

- Influence of length and formality on report structure
- How short and long reports differ in writing style
- Choosing an appropriate form for short reports
- Adapting the procedures for writing short reports to many other types of reports
- Writing longer reports that meet readers' needs and are easy to follow

Length and Formality

- Long problems and formal contexts require a more complex makeup.
- Short problems and informal contexts need a simpler makeup.

The Report Classification Plan



Report Components

- Title fly
- Title page
- Transmittal message
- Table of contents
- Executive summary
 - Direct order
 - Indirect order

Characteristics of Short Reports

- Little need for introductory information
- Predominance of direct order
- More personal writing style
- Less need for a structured coherence plan

Forms of Short Reports

- Short report
- Letter report
- Email report
- Other forms, such as newsletters, pamphlets, and white papers

Common Types of Reports

- Routine operational report
- Progress report
- Problem-solving report
- Audit report
- Meeting minutes

Organization of a Long Report

- Prefatory components
 - Title Fly
 - Title Page
 - Authorization Message
 - Transmittal Message (or Preface or Foreword)
 - Table of Contents (and List of Illustrations)
 - Executive Summary
- The Report Proper
 - Introduction
 - Report Findings
 - Summary , Conclusion , and/or Recommendations
- Appended Parts
 - Bibliography/ Reference
 - Appendix/Annexure

Sample Transmittal Message

Hamilton County Solid Waste District

Dear Jeanine:

Here is an in-depth qualitative study of Hamilton County residents' attitudes toward recycling, which you authorized on December 3, 2012.

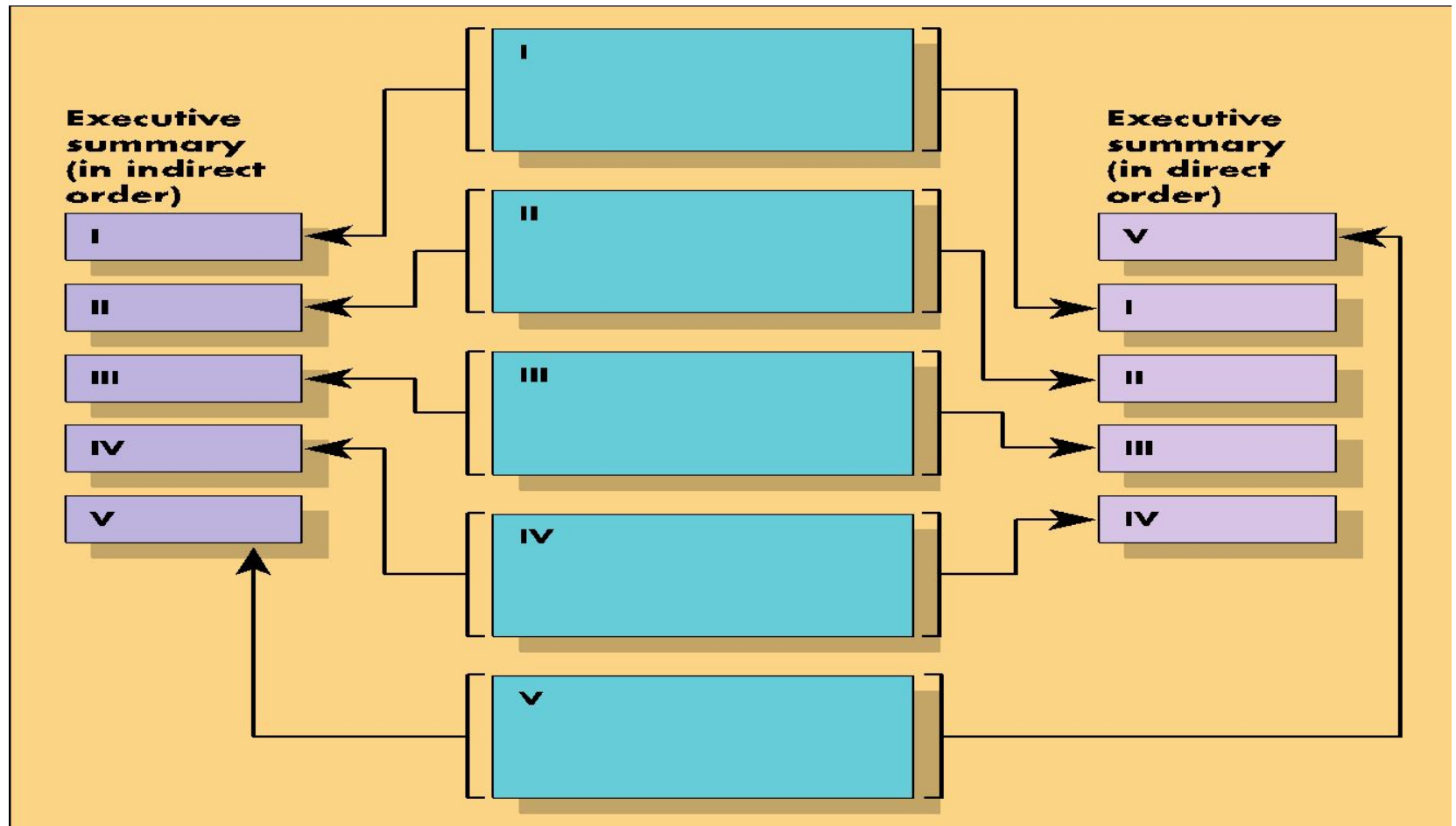
We contracted the services of Advanced Marketing, a Cincinnati marketing firm, to conduct the study in collaboration with four representatives from the District. The study revealed positive and negative attitudes that Sometimes Recyclers in Hamilton County have toward recycling. This report describes their attitudes in detail.

In light of these findings, the report identifies several strategies that can be implemented to make our next recycling campaign a success.

Thank you for authorizing this research. I look forward to working with you to create our most effective campaign ever.

Sincerely yours,

Executive Summary



The Report Introduction

- The report introduction
- Origin of the report
- Problem and purpose
- Scope
- Limitations
- Historical background
- Sources and methods of collecting information
- Definitions, initialisms, and acronyms
- Report preview

The Report Body

- Uses a logical and appropriate pattern of organization
- Uses clear, parallel headings to announce each section's contents
- Uses tables, charts, and any other graphics that can help the writer present detailed data and help the reader gather a lot of information at once
- Indicates clearly at each point where the information came from
- Uses coherence helpers to move the readers smoothly through the report and help them follow the report's logical structure

The Report Ending

- A summary . . .
pulls together the key findings of the report.
- Conclusions . . .
interpret the key findings to explain what they mean.
- Recommendations . . .
actually propose action, based on the key findings and what they mean.

Coherence Through Transitions

- All the evidence appears to justify our taking steps to correct the problem. The next section discusses and evaluates possible solutions.
- For these reasons, three of the work plans are not acceptable to employees. They strongly favor the fourth, which is the focus of the next section.
- Having concluded that the machine has failed, we must determine whether it can be altered to meet our needs.
- The preceding evidence makes clear that sales are likely to decline sharply in the next quarter. Before we adjust for this development, however, it is necessary to consider the outlook for the economy in the region. This analysis follows.